



Self-Evaluation Report for the Institutional Accreditation of Université La Sagesse

Date of Submission of Final Draft:

August 1st, 2025

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2 General Information on Université La Sagesse

2.1 Core Facts and Profile

2.1.1 Brief History

In 1874, Monsignor Joseph Debs, the Maronite Archbishop of Beirut, founded the Secondary School of La Sagesse. His vision was to create an inclusive and diverse learning environment that welcomed students from various religious and confessional backgrounds. Recognizing the growing demand for higher education, Archbishop Debs established the Higher Institute of Law in 1875, driven by his dedication to offering equitable access to knowledge.

La Sagesse Higher Institute for Law gained prominence during the Ottoman Empire, a time when advocating for rights was a perilous endeavour. It was a pioneer in teaching Ottoman Law, Islamic jurisprudence, and, most notably, Comparative Law in Arabic within the Arab region. The teaching of Islamic jurisprudence at the Archbishop's Institute carried profound national and interfaith significance. From the founding in 1875 until the temporary closure at the onset of World War I in 1912, renowned legal and administrative professionals who served Lebanon and neighbouring countries graduated from the Institute.

In the 1960s, the Lebanese government decided to restrict law degrees to the public university. However, an exception was granted to La Sagesse Institute to revive its law programme based on its historical standing and the decree originally granted by the Ottoman Sultan. The institute was officially reestablished on November 6, 1961, shortly before the enactment of the Law on the Organization of Private Higher Education on December 26, 1961. It was under this legal framework that the Higher Institute of Law of La Sagesse received official authorization to become part of Université La Sagesse, by virtue of Decree No. 1947.

By 1999, ULS achieved three major milestones in less than a year:

- On June 28, 1999, the cornerstone for the new university buildings in Furn El Chebbak was laid.
- On December 1, 1999, the Council of Ministers approved the establishment of new faculties at ULS, as formalized in Decree No. 1947, issued on December 21, 1999.
- On January 3, 2000, the Pontifical Council for Education in Rome recognized ULS as a pontifical university, granting it the exclusive privilege of awarding degrees in Canon Law.

Today, ULS is one of six Catholic universities in Lebanon, comprising eight faculties offering twenty-seven programmes with multiple concentrations. The primary languages of instruction are English and French, with some courses offered in Arabic for Lebanese Legal studies.

Listed in order of seniority, the eight faculties are as follows:

- Faculty of Law (FOL)

- Faculty of Canon Law (FCL)
- Faculty of Religious and Theological Sciences (FRTS)
- Faculty of Economics and Business Administration (FEBA)
- Faculty of Political Science and International Relations (FPSIR)
- Faculty of Tourism and Hotel Management (FTHM)
- Faculty of Public Health (FPH)
- Faculty of Engineering (FOE)

In addition to the aforementioned faculties, the university houses auxiliary units, research centers, and administrative offices⁴.

2.1.2 ULS Core Values, Mission, and Vision

Core Values

Rooted in Greater Lebanon, witnessing its founding and subsequent development, ULS promotes, in its mission of education, research, and community involvement, the Christian and universal values of freedom, justice, social responsibility, and respect for human dignity.

Mission

Founded in 1875 by the Maronite Archdiocese of Beirut, ULS is a private, non-profit Lebanese Catholic institution.

Open to the international community, ULS prepares generations of Lebanese men and women for the evolving job market and supports active members of society in their pursuit of knowledge. Sagesians are called upon to be vectors of progress and innovation. Free, open, and committed, they work for a spirit of solidarity in citizenship and a society founded on justice, transparency, and ethics.

Vision

ULS intends to become a center for fundamental and applied research that meets the evolving needs of the market. Being an environment conducive to pluralism and cultural diversity, ULS aims to be a privileged space for intercultural dialogue. It aims to nurture the entrepreneurial spirit of young people, thus facilitating their professional integration. Rooted in the City, ULS strives to promote the culture of life and family. Aware of the university's role in shaping the public sphere, it will promote a culture of institutionalization, transparency, fighting corruption, and human well-being.

2.1.3 Focus Areas in Teaching and Research

2.1.3.1 Focus Areas in Teaching

ULS adopts a holistic educational model and a mission-driven approach to teaching that emphasizes both professional readiness and humanistic development. This dual commitment is evident in the distinct yet complementary teaching focuses of faculties. Some programmes

⁴ Refer to ULS Bylaws provided in Appendix 2

are designed to equip students with the necessary skills for specialized careers in professional fields, while others emphasize intellectual growth, personal development, and service to the community and the Church.

Professionally-Oriented Teaching

Several faculties at ULS tailor their teaching to address the evolving demands of the job market, emphasizing applied knowledge, technical skills, and industry relevance:

- **FOL:** The curriculum aims to deepen legal knowledge while developing analytical, argumentative, and research skills. Instruction is case-based, comparative, and practice-oriented, preparing students for legal careers. For instance, *the undergraduate Legal Clinic initiative provides insights into the role of lawyers in civil society. Students are well prepared to pass the Bar exam upon completion of their Bachelor's degree.*
- **FEBA:** The teaching approach aligns with the competencies sought in local and global business environments. Courses blend a solid theoretical foundation with advanced practical applications across various corporate sectors. *By integrating simulations, case studies, and data-driven learning, the programme enhances decision-making skills and promotes an entrepreneurial mindset.*
- **FPSIR:** Programmes focus on both theoretical concepts and real-world applications. Students engage in scenario-based simulations, policy analysis, and diplomatic exposure, preparing them for careers in international organizations, government institutions, and civil society. *Graduate-level NGO management courses are taught by instructors actively involved in civil society, sharing their expertise with students.*
- **FOE:** An innovation-driven approach characterizes the teaching methodology. Programmes balance theoretical instruction in sciences with project-based learning across various engineering disciplines. Emphasizing design thinking, problem-solving, and hands-on experimentation, students utilize modern laboratories and simulation tools. *A final-year project and an industry internship are required for graduation.*
- **FTHM:** The teaching approach alternates between academic coursework with experiential learning. Students explore both operational and strategic facets of the hospitality and tourism industries through internships, projects, and service labs. *While the programme aims to prepare future managers, hands-on experience across all industry aspects is essential as in kitchen labs, warehousing, housekeeping.*
- **FPH:** The programme for all three distinct majors merges scientific knowledge with clinical practice, emphasizing simulation-based learning, internships, and community-based care models. *Students are well prepared to succeed in the colloquial exams in Nursing Sciences and Physiotherapy.*

Spiritual and Humanistic Oriented Teaching

In addition to professional readiness, ULS is committed to the integral development of the person. Several faculties place special emphasis on personal formation, values education, and service:

- **FRTS:** Teaching is designed to endorse intellectual reflection, spiritual growth, and pastoral engagement. *Programmes are not only addressed to the clergy but to the wider audience.*
- **FCL:** Teaching focuses on the internal legal framework of the Church. Students gain a profound understanding of ecclesiastical norms and their pastoral application. *Graduates are prepared for roles in diocesan tribunals, ecclesial governance, and canonical consultation.*

2.1.3.2 Teaching Philosophy

ULS teaching philosophy is anchored in three key pillars:

- **Bridging Academic Specialization and Real-World Practice:** Instructors serve as disciplinary vectors who translate academic specialization into practical relevance, ensuring students gain both in-depth knowledge and the competencies needed in the job market.
- **Guiding Foundational to Applied Learning:** Instructors guide students through a developmental learning path. They introduce students to foundational disciplines then facilitate a transition into more applied learning through hands-on exercises, simulation labs, and case studies. This structured pedagogical approach ensures that students build a robust theoretical base and learn to apply knowledge with confidence in real-world settings.
- **Mentoring Career Readiness and Experiential Learning:** Instructors are mentors who prepare students for life after graduation. They integrate fieldwork, internships, and applied projects into their teaching, often in collaboration with the Center for Career Development (CCD) and external stakeholders. Instructors actively contribute to students' career development and professional identity.

2.1.3.3 Focus Areas in Research

ULS is committed to supporting impactful research that responds to local, regional, and global challenges. In line with its mission and vision, its research agenda emphasizes applied and interdisciplinary themes that promote sustainable development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and human well-being.

ULS prioritizes the development of research capacities and infrastructures to support knowledge creation that benefits society and informs policymakers. It supports research through funding for conferences, journal submissions, access to databases like EBSCO, JSTOR,

the electronic legal database Saderlex⁵, London Stock Exchange Group (LSEG) data and analytics, including Datastream, as well as resources for laboratories and researchers. ULS also nurtures collaboration with the private sector and international bodies to expand research funding and strives to transfer research outcomes into academic programmes to ensure their relevance and impact.

ULS eight faculties contribute significantly to the university's research output:

- **FOL** engages in research in private, public, digital law, AI governance, mergers & acquisitions, public procurement, and arbitration studies (FIDIC⁶ disputes, international commercial arbitration, and investment treaty arbitration). Ongoing research addresses Lebanon's governance challenges and legal dimensions of Oil & Gas Energy Law. Additionally, research examines the evolving intersection of Law and Technology, with a focus on AI's impact on legal processes and the use of blockchain in dispute resolution.
- **FRTS, FCL, and the Family Institute** focus on biblical, theological, and ecclesial research (Old and New Testaments, pastoral theology, ecumenism, theology and sciences of marriage and family, and canon law). Their multidisciplinary research emphasizes the relevance of theological sources in a pluralistic world and explores the relationship between Christian faith, ecclesial needs/rights, and terrestrial realities.
- **FEBA** conducts interdisciplinary research at the intersection of technology, society, and markets. Focus areas include the impact of AI, big data, and digital transformation on business models and decision-making. Research in political economy and socioeconomic transformations explores policy, inequality, and economic resilience. Studies on cryptocurrency and blockchain examine their implications for finance and regulation. The faculty also addresses sustainable development and territorial planning, marketing, consumer behavior, and strategic management. Additionally, research in transportation engineering and safety supports infrastructure planning and mobility solutions.
- **FPSIR** focuses its research on assessing crisis response and management strategies at the national and international levels, namely the effectiveness and societal impacts of NGOs, particularly in conflict and post-crisis settings. It also investigates the evolving role of public diplomacy in shaping global relationships, soft power dynamics, informing policy design, and strengthening institutional accountability.
- **FTHM** focuses its research on hotel and restaurant management, with an emphasis on service quality, operational efficiency, and sustainability. It also explores food safety practices, tourism development with an emphasis on culture and sustainability, and effective event management strategies.
- **FPH** engages in research addressing key public health challenges, including epidemiology and psychosocial risks associated with telework, healthcare environments, and school ergonomics, particularly in preventing back pain among

⁵ SADERLex is a comprehensive legal research platform developed by SADER Legal Publishing that provides access to laws, court decisions, and legal references from various Arab countries, primarily in Arabic.

⁶ FIDIC is a French language acronym for *Fédération Internationale Des Ingénieurs-Conseils*, which means the international federation of consulting engineers.

children. It explores strategies to improve hospital management practices and staff well-being to enhance care quality. Additional research areas include the integration of physiotherapy into public health strategies, the role of medical imaging in education, prevention, and treatment, and advancing nursing science education to meet future healthcare demands.

- **FOE** conducts interdisciplinary research across five departments, focusing on healthcare technologies, AI, sustainability, and advanced materials. Biomedical Engineering leads in medical imaging, biomaterials, and wearable health devices. Mechatronics advances intelligent control, biomedical safety, and AI hardware. Computer and Telecommunication Engineering emphasizes AI, NLP, and smart systems. Biofood Engineering works on agri-food waste valorization and functional foods. Chemical Engineering targets sustainable energy processes and innovative materials.

Collaborative projects and international partnerships support the strong applied research output of the eight faculties. Together, they advance a dynamic and socially responsive research culture. This approach drives the generation of knowledge and the development of innovative solutions to societal challenges.

2.1.4 Number of students, faculty, and staff

2.1.4.1 Students

ULS currently counts 4,366 students enrolled in degree-granting programmes. Figure 2 shows that between 2019 and 2025, student enrolment grew steadily from 3,457 to 4,366. This growth spans both undergraduate and graduate levels, with a consistently balanced gender distribution (Figure 3).

Figure 2 – Evolution of the Number of Students per Gender during the Period of 2019-2025

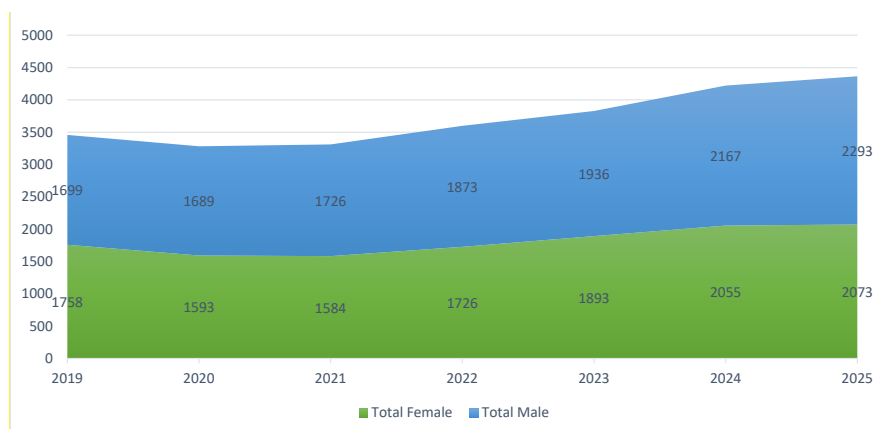


Figure 3 – Graduate and Undergraduate Distribution per Gender between 2019 and 2025

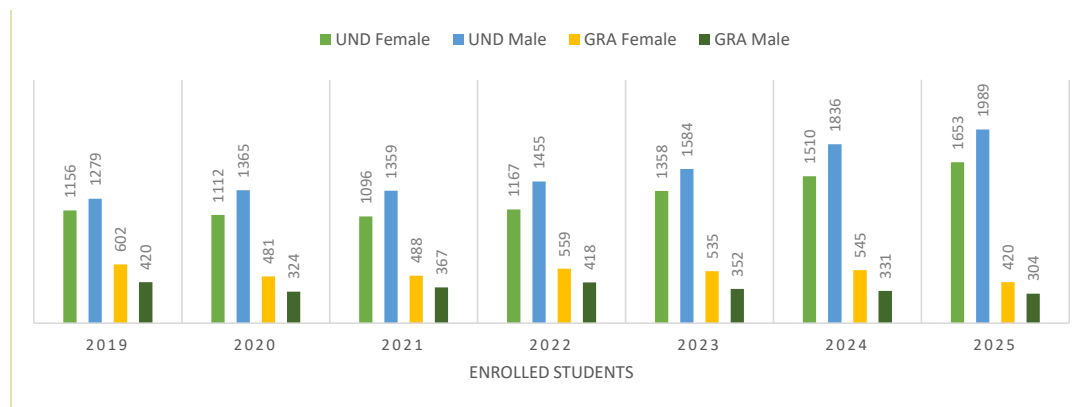
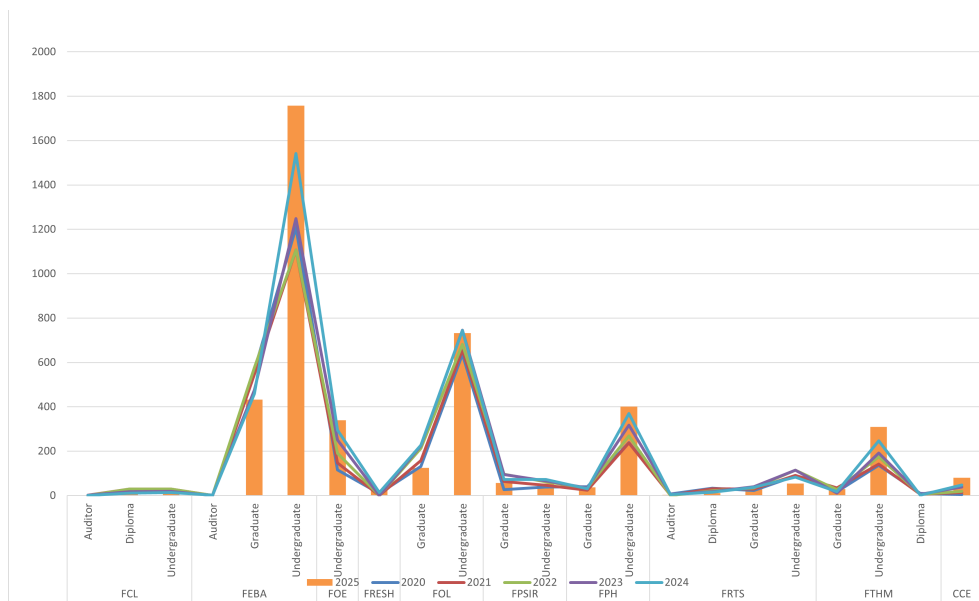


Figure 4 reveals notable trends in student enrolment across various faculties. FEBA and FOL show the highest number of students, with FEBA seeing a substantial increase in undergraduate enrolments, particularly in 2025. FPH and FTHM show a slightly upward trend in enrolments over the years, reflecting gradual growth in these fields. Additionally, the Center for Continuing Education (CCE), launched in 2023-2024, has emerged with a focus on diploma and professional development programmes, adding a new dimension to the university's educational offerings. Overall, the data highlights an increase in undergraduate student numbers in 2025 across most faculties, especially in the more professionally - oriented programs.

Figure 4 – Distribution of Students across Faculties



2.1.4.2 Academic Staff

The full-time Academic Staff at ULS is composed of 86 individuals, categorized into three types of contracts: Category A (exclusive full-time) with 47 academic staff, Category B (non-exclusive full-time) with 30, and Category C (non-exclusive with no administrative load) with 9. In terms of academic rank, ULS comprises 35 Assistant Professors, 29 Lecturers, and 17 Associate Professors. Regarding qualifications, 54 hold a PhD, while 23 hold a Master's degree. Gender representation is relatively balanced, with 50 male and 36 female faculty members. Leadership roles include 32 Coordinators, 16 Chairs, 10 full-time instructors, 7 Deans, and 1 Acting Dean. The Academic Staff's international background is reflected in their graduation countries, with the majority holding degrees from France (38) and Lebanon (36), showcasing ULS commitment to academic diversity. *Figure 5* illustrates the classification of ULS full-time Academic Staff.

To retain and attract qualified Academic Staff, ULS takes strategic measures. It offers a comprehensive benefits package to its full-time instructors⁷ and provides a wide range of benefits, research funding, teaching load reductions, and a supportive research environment, including sabbaticals and international mobility.

Figure 5 – Classification of Full-Time Academic Staff



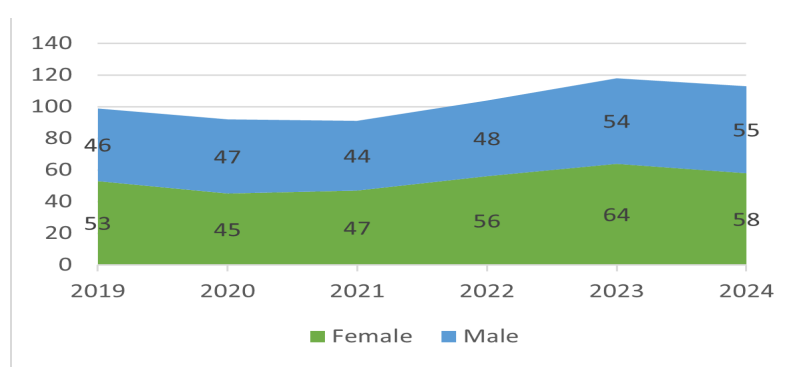
⁷ Refer to Section 3.4.3.4 of this SER

2.1.4.3 Administrative Staff

The number of Administrative Staff at ULS between 2019 and 2024 has shown a general upward trend, growing from 99 in 2019 to a peak of 118 in 2023, despite a slight decrease to 113 in 2024 (Figure 6). Notably, the number of female staff increased from 53 in 2019 to a high of 64 in 2023, indicating strengthened gender representation.

The majority of Administrative Staff over the past two academic years hold a Bachelor's degree, with a gradual increase in those holding a Master's degree, rising from 18 in 2023-2024 to 20 in 2024-2025, while PhD holders remained a small, stable minority.

Figure 6 – Number and Gender Equality Among ULS Administrative Staff



2.1.5 Information on public or private funding bodies

ULS relies primarily on student tuition fees as its main source of financial income. However, in its ongoing efforts to diversify financial resources and strengthen its academic and social mission, ULS also receives modest support from several public and private funding sources that contribute to student development and institutional sustainability. For instance, Aid to the Church in Need (ACN) grants an annual donation to FRTS students, the Alaywan Family Foundation and L'Œuvre d'Orient grants to the Office of Student Affairs, with further donations and sponsorships from Arabia Insurance (supporting the development of a continuing education program) and Online Money Transfer (OMT) also contribute to promoting equal access to education and advancing the university's mission. Collectively, these contributions represent approximately 1% of ULS total income.

Student exchange and academic staff mobility are also encouraged by international organizations like AUF and the Erasmus+ program, and foreign embassies, allowing them to an international exposure by covering a large part of their travel and accommodation expenses.

2.2 Internal Organizational Structure and Governance

As per ULS Bylaws, the governance structure of ULS is designed to ensure representation and active participation in decision-making of academic and administrative staff, as well as students. This structure relies on a clear definition of leadership roles, faculty governance, financial oversight, student affairs management, and institutional decision-making bodies (Figure 7).

Leadership and Executive Governance

At the highest level, the Maronite Archbishop of the Diocese of Beirut serves as the Chancellor of ULS, holding both ecclesiastical and institutional authority. The President, appointed by the Chancellor for a renewable three-year term, is responsible for the university's management, strategic development, and legal representation. The President has the authority to appoint Vice-Presidents, Deans, and key administrative and academic positions, subject to the Chancellor's consent and approval.

Vice-Presidents support the President by overseeing academic, research, and administrative functions as well as relations with local and international partners. They are appointed for variable terms and play a central role in policy implementation and institutional development. Their mandate is directly linked to the President's tenure.

Faculty Governance

Each faculty at ULS is led by a Dean, who is appointed for a renewable three-year term. Deans are responsible for faculty administration, academic programme oversight, recruitment, faculty development and budget management. They chair the Faculty Council, which includes Associate Deans, Chairs of departments, and elected representatives of academic staff and students. The Faculty Council is responsible for curriculum development, strategic planning, and quality assurance within the faculty. Directors of faculty-affiliated entities are appointed by the President based on the Deans' recommendations (PULSE, Export Promotion Center).

Financial Oversight and Administration

The Chief Financial Officer (CFO) ensures the financial stability of the university by managing the budget, investment strategies, and financial compliance. The CFO oversees financial risk management, approves expenditures, supervises internal controls, and designs institutional financial planning.

Office of Student Affairs and the Office of Registrar

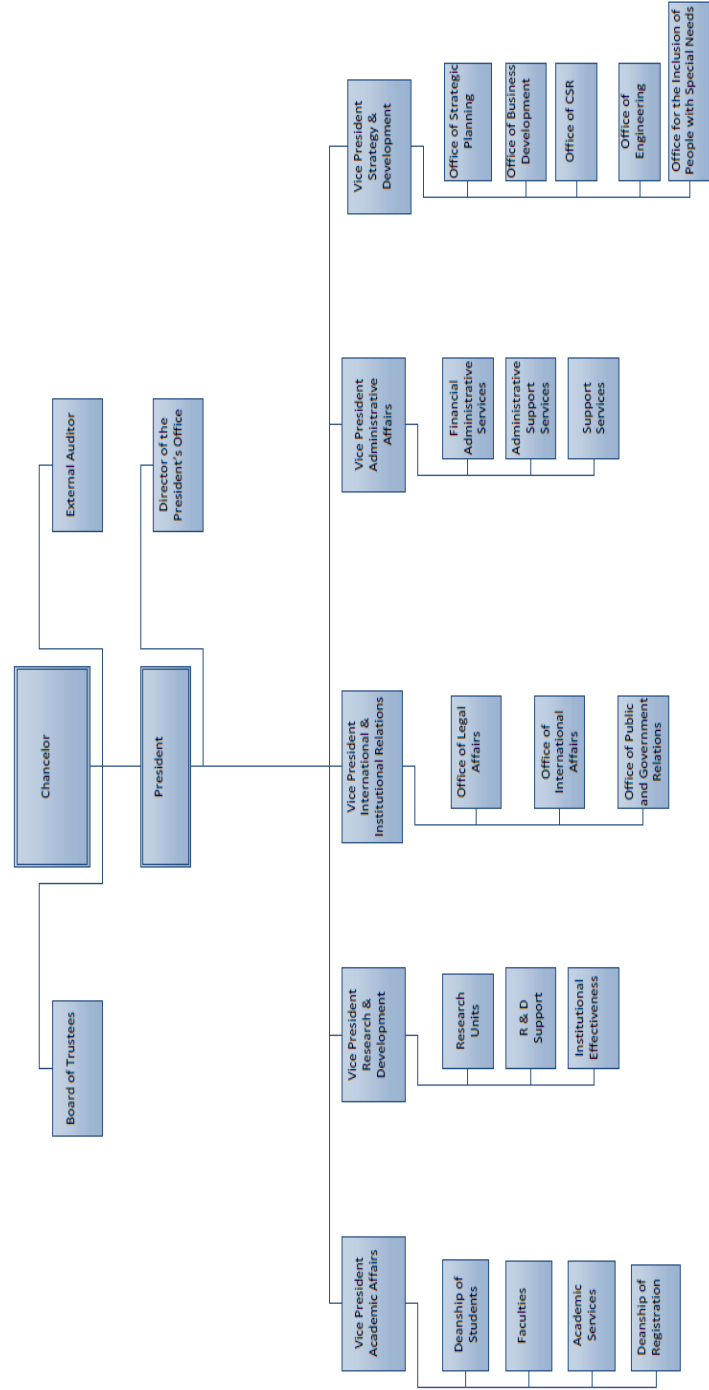
The Dean of Students supervises the activities of the Office of Student Affairs (OSA), the Office of Admissions and Orientation (OAO), the Office of Alumni Relations (OAR), and the CCD. Dean of Students ensures that student needs and concerns are integrated into institutional policies and is involved in disciplinary matters and student elections as well.

The Dean of Registration supervises the Office of Registrar (OR)'s activities, including the management of student records, enrolment, graduation audits, and the issuance of diplomas. The Dean of Registration ensures compliance with ULS Rules and Regulations for Academic Affairs (RRAA, Appendix 3).

University Governing Bodies

- The Board of Trustees, appointed by the Chancellor, is responsible for approving strategic development plans, budget allocations, and amendments to the university's bylaws.
- The University Council, chaired by the President or by the Chancellor when present, is the highest executive body overseeing academic, administrative, financial, and disciplinary matters. It establishes institutional policies, approves academic programmes, and submits key proposals to the Board of Trustees for final approval. The ULS Council is composed of the President, who convenes and chairs it, the Vice-Presidents, the Deans of faculties, the Chief Financial Officer, the Dean of Students, the Registrar, the elected representative of the full-time academic staff, and the elected representative of the students.

Figure 7 – ULS Organizational Chart



The internal governance of ULS is structured to ensure efficient decision-making and institutional accountability. By involving academic decision-makers such as the Deans and the elected representative of Full-time Academic Staff, along with the Chief Financial Officer, Directors of Auxiliary Units to Faculties, and the elected representative of students, the governance model promotes transparency and academic excellence and supports institutional growth. A more detailed organizational chart, outlining the full structure of the university, including all offices and services under each Vice-President, is provided in Appendix 4.

Trained financial aid advisors at the Office of Students Affairs are available to guide students through the systemized process of aid application, understanding available options, and managing their educational expenses. ULS also promotes financial literacy among its students to help them make informed decisions.

2.3.3.4 Commitment to Sustainability and Quality

ULS has established 2 main entities in order to confirm its commitment, embedding both principles into strategic planning and its daily operations. ULS promotes eco-responsible resource management and long-term viability through sustainable practices across all entities. QA is supported by a dedicated steering committee and the systematization of internal processes.

2.4 Information on International Activities, Networks, and Partners

As part of its strategic planning and commitment to academic excellence via international collaboration, ULS has developed an important network of partnerships with global institutions. These partnerships focus on academic and administrative cooperation, faculty mobility, student exchange, research initiatives, and professional training programmes.

2.4.1 Academic International Activities, Networks, and Partnerships

ULS has established a diverse range of international academic partnerships with reputable institutions across Europe to develop academic collaboration, joint research projects, entrepreneurship support, and double degree programmes.

Table 2 outlines the established partnerships and collaborations. Beneficiaries of these partnerships span multiple faculties, as well as administrative and academic entities across ULS.

Table 2 - International Academic Partnerships and Beneficiaries at ULS

Institution	Description	Beneficiaries
Institut catholique de Paris (ICP)	Partnership under a framework agreement	Different Faculties
Université de Bordeaux	Partnership under a framework agreement	All ULS Entities (Faculties + Admin)
Université de Bordeaux	Master's Double Degree (MBA - MIAAGE)	FEBA
Bordeaux Institute of Technology - INP	Master's Double Degree & Student, faculty, and research exchanges	FOE
Université de Lille	Master's Double Degree in Hospitality Management	FPH
Université Catholique de Lille - Faculté de Droit	Exchange, research collaboration, Erasmus+ Projects	FOL
Université Catholique de Lille - Faculté de Gestion, Economie et Sciences	Student & Staff Exchange, Research Cooperation	FEBA + FOE
JUNIA - Grande école d'ingénieurs	Academic partnership under a framework agreement	FOE
Rennes School of Business (RSB)	Double Degree (Bachelor's & Master's)	FEBA
Université de Lorraine - PEEL	Entrepreneurship Cooperation & Support	All ULS Faculties
Ecole Hôtelière de Lausanne (EHL)	Certified Member	FTHM
Universita Della Calabria - UNICAL	MOU: Mobility & Student Exchange, Research Projects, Conferences	All ULS Entities (Faculties + Admin)
Pontificio Istituto Orientale	Programme Affiliation	FCL
Pontificio Teologico Giovanni Paolo II - Matrimonio e Famiglia	Cooperation Agreement	FRTS

2.4.2 International Partnerships and Collaborations

In addition to its academic partnerships, ULS has established a range of strategic collaborations with prominent international and national organizations as well foreign embassies. These partnerships contribute to the university's mission of promoting academic excellence, employability, and sustainable development. Notable collaborations include:

- Agence Universitaire de la Francophonie (AUF) (www.auf.org)

- Amideast (<https://www.amideast.org/>)
- Association Bilan Carbone (www.abc-transitionbas carbone.fr)
- CNRS (Lebanese National Research Council) (www.cnrs.edu.lb)
- Digital Marketing Institute International (DMI)(www.digitalmarketinginstitute.com)
- HR Certification Institute (HRCI) (www.hrci.org)
- Human Capital Management (HCM) (www.hc-mgt.com)
- Institut Français du Liban (www.institutfrancais-liban.com)
- International Foundation for Women's Empowerment (www.foundationforwomen.net)
- Istituto Italiano di Cultura di Beirut (<https://iicbeirut.esteri.it>)
- National Anti-Corruption Commission (nacc.gov)
- Refinitiv - LSEG
- United Nations Development Program (undp.org)
- UNWomen (unwomen.org)
- USAID (www.usaid.gov)

2.4.3 Institutional and International Networks

ULS is an active member of several prestigious academic and accreditation networks that strengthen its academic visibility, and contribute to shared missions in HE across regional and global contexts:

- Association of Arab Universities (AarU) (aar u.edu. jo)
- Association to Advance Collegiate Schools of Business (AACSB) member.
- Conférence des Recteurs de la Région du Moyen-Orient (C2R)
- Conférence des Recteurs des Universités Françaises de la Région du Moyen-Orient (CONFREMO)
- Education Development Center (EDC-HECD)
- Fédération des Universités Catholiques Européennes (FUCE) (www.fuce.eu)
- Fédération Internationale des Universités Catholiques (FIUC) (www.fiuc-ifcu.org)
- FIBAA - Accreditation for the Faculty of Law and the Faculty of Economics and Business Administration
- Universities Association of Lebanon (UAOLB) (www.uaolb.org)

2.4.4 AUF Partnership and Activities

AUF supports high-capacity development programmes tailored for francophone educational institutions. ULS benefited from a rich programme of academic development activities offered by AUF during 2023–2024.:

- Artificial Intelligence in Teaching and Assessment
- Designing a MOOC/CLOM
- Distance Training on Research Methodology
- Expertise Mission to Develop ULS Center for Languages
- Expertise Mission to Develop ULS Center for Teaching and Learning (CTL)
- Flipped Classroom Techniques

- Programme Learning Outcomes (PLOs) and Course Learning Outcomes (CLOs) - Alignment with Mission, Vision, and Values
- Training on Language for Specific Purposes (FOS/FOU Methodology in Language Teaching)
- Workshop on Scientific Publication Methodology

2.4.5 HECD Programme (USAID-Funded) - Capacity Building Activities

The HECD Program, funded by USAID, aims to enhance institutional capabilities and workforce readiness. Between 2021 and 2025, the following initiatives have been implemented:

- Be Your Own Boss (BYOB) TOT Online Course Workshop
- Career Counselling and Advising Physical Workshop
- Data for Decision Making
- Design Thinking
- Employer Engagement: A Comprehensive Approach
- Grant Writing Training
- IT Tools for Teaching WRN Effectively Online
- Mental Health in the Workplace
- Strategies and Models of Employer Engagement
- Student & Alumni Data Tracking
- Universal Design for Learning
- Work Ready Now (WRN) TOT Physical Course Workshop

2.5 Student Support Services

ULS is committed to delivering comprehensive and inclusive student support services that cater to the academic, personal, and professional needs of its diverse student body. Each faculty at ULS contributes to a robust ecosystem of advising, mentoring, career development, and engagement, ensuring that students are supported throughout their educational journey.

2.5.1 Academic Advising and Course Planning

ULS faculties offer structured academic advising tailored to students' academic paths. All full-timers play the role of academic advisors and guide students in their course selection and programme requirements through regular in-person or online meetings, supported by timely communication via email, Moodle, SIS, and Microsoft Teams. Advisors offer personalized support during and beyond office hours. Some faculties send semester schedules by email and hold orientation sessions, while others use formal and informal methods, including WhatsApp groups and lists, to share key updates. These tools ensure students stay informed and engaged.

For instance, at FRTS and FCL, advising is oral and personalized, with administrative staff managing records and helping students understand course structures, electives, and calendars.

2.5.2 Support for At-Risk Students

ULS demonstrates a strong commitment to academic inclusivity by providing targeted support to students facing academic, psychological, or social challenges. Academic advisors help underperforming students revise their study progress, prioritize essential courses, and adopt effective study strategies, with regular monitoring to track progress. Tailored support includes one-on-one counseling, peer tutoring, and additional learning resources. Faculty offer mentoring and extra coursework to address learning gaps. Students facing non-academic difficulties are referred to appropriate services.

The university also promotes inclusive education by accommodating students with disabilities and offering them adapted learning environments and services. The Office for the Inclusion of Students with Specific Needs coordinates with concerned entities to ensure that teaching materials, classroom settings, and assessment methods accommodate students' needs. This includes extended test times, assistive technologies, and modified course materials when required.

2.5.3 Career Development and Planning

ULS nurtures student employability and long-term professional growth through its CCD, which supports job placement, internship opportunities, and personalized career counselling. The university adopts a comprehensive approach that blends personalized support and market connectivity to prepare students for successful professional integration through a wide-reaching network of employers across various industries. To streamline employer-student engagement, CCD utilizes the Symplicity professional integration platform to link students from all faculties with employers, while also conducting resume-building and job interview workshops and workplace communication. These services are complemented by the initiatives of the OAR, which maintains active communication with ULS graduates. Alumni input is integrated into this process to enhance ULS students' readiness for the job market.

Faculties support students' career development through research involvement, networking opportunities, and academic events with industry, government, and humanitarian partners. FPSIR, for example, maintains detailed records of internships and training, gathering feedback from external stakeholders to ensure relevance. Students also engage with professionals, such as diplomats, through specialized training courses. Since 2022, FPSIR students have volunteered in a crisis management simulation involving the Red Cross, Lebanese Army, Civil Defense, and others. They receive preparatory training and provide feedback afterward to enhance future exercises.

2.5.4 Faculty-Student Interaction and Governance

Faculty-student engagement is encouraged across ULS through formal and informal initiatives. This includes a combination of personalized counselling and advanced electronic service-support systems. Each student is assigned a ULS email for seamless communication, while platforms like SIS, Moodle, MSTEams and Symplicity ensure efficient academic, administrative, and career support. Faculties involve student representatives in governance bodies such as Faculty Councils and promote transparency and participation in decision-making. Regular communication and feedback loops ensure that student voices are heard and academic services are improved.

2.5.5 Extracurricular and Community Engagement

ULS supports student participation in co-curricular and community-oriented activities that enrich the academic experience¹⁶. They actively participate in prestigious international competitions, achieving top rankings. For instance, the students of FOL *represented Lebanon at the Jessup Moot Court in Washington, D.C., consecutively in 2023 and 2024. FEBA students stood out in finance by reaching the podium in major global contests and excelling in the CFA and Virtual Stock Exchange competitions in 2023, 2024, and 2025.*

Additionally, the Office for International Relations supports students in international mobility with information on exchange, grants, and recognition procedures.

Beyond academics, ULS students are engaged in community initiatives, sports leadership, and technological innovation, demonstrating their diverse talents and commitment to impact. *For example, FPH students engage in awareness campaigns and health-related events, while FPSIR students participate in crisis simulations and policy debates. FRTS students are involved in pastoral and community service and are encouraged to engage in inter-university experiences facilitated by the Office of International Affairs.*

Student support services at ULS are integral to its academic culture and strategic mission, ensuring academic success, well-being, and career readiness. Each ULS entity actively contributes to this holistic, student-centered ecosystem of care, guidance and development.

2.6 Study Programmes

2.6.1 List of the study programmes

¹⁶ Refer to the video of ULS Students' Achievements and Extracurricular Activities realized in 2024, provided in Appendix 12

and compliance with institutional and MEHE standards. Once this audit is completed, the student is able to retrieve their official documents and graduate.

In addition, and in line with its commitment to transparency and sound governance, ULS undergoes an annual external financial audit. Conducted in accordance with International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) and Lebanese regulations, and aligned with International Standards on Auditing (ISA), the audit includes risk assessment, control testing, and substantive procedures targeting key financial areas such as tuition revenues, payroll, and capital expenditures. The audit concludes with the issuance of an Independent Auditor's Report and a management letter containing key observations and recommendations, ensuring the integrity of financial reporting and reinforcing institutional accountability.

3.2 Design of the Study Programmes

3.2.1 External framework for the design and content of study programmes

The curriculum of ULS is designed to meet international quality standards and with respect to the tentative regulatory framework established by the Ministry of Education and Higher Education (MEHE) and the Directorate General for Higher Education (DGHE). All academic programmes comply with relevant decrees, circulars, and decisions that govern higher education institutions in Lebanon.

3.2.1.1 Ministerial referral authorities

In Lebanon, each private Higher Education Institution (HEI) has the autonomy to design the content of its academic programmes. However, the Council of Higher Education (CHE) and the respective Technical Committees have established general guidelines and regulations for the approval of these programmes³⁰. When a HEI applies for programme authorization or recognition from MEHE, it must provide comprehensive details, including course descriptions and classification, the number of credits, and the available learning resources. For each program, the applications are reviewed by Technical Committees and Specialized Committees to ensure that they comply with the highest standards of academic excellence. All decisions are published in the Official Journal and approved by the Council of Ministers.

At the internal level, the reform of programmes is revised by ULS Curriculum Committee, which evaluates proposals for the creation of new academic programmes and the revision of study programmes, prepared by Faculty Curricular Committees and approved by faculty councils. The committee ensures in its evaluation that the proposals comply with ULS RRAA, the requirements of MEHE, the developmental strategies of faculties as well as to ULS competencies framework. The revision of programmes allows to align ULS academic programmes with the skills requirements and the needs of the labour market.

³⁰ The application of any programme submitted by a university to MEHE in Lebanon goes through four stages: Authorization of the program, Authorization to commence teaching, Recognition, and Renewal of recognition.

3.2.1.2 National legislation

ULS curriculum is structured to provide a balanced and comprehensive educational experience, integrating core knowledge, specialized courses, and experiential learning. Undergraduate and graduate courses at ULS are classified as follows:

- **University General Education Requirements** are courses that aim to complete the ULS student's academic profile providing them with diverse skills, competencies, and culture, developing an entrepreneurial spirit, becoming an engaged and active citizen, communicating ideas, and promoting acceptance of religious diversity, ethics, and moral development, regardless of the chosen major degree. They constitute twelve (12) credits and are accounted for in the calculation of the total credit requirements of most undergraduate programmes.
- **Faculty Core/Major requirement courses** are mandatory courses, providing the foundation for a given program. The set of core courses constitutes the matrix of a programme and covers the learning outcomes of the program. It constitutes at least 50% of the total number of credits required by a program.
- **Concentration requirements courses** are courses selected amongst a set of courses related to a major programme within a specific field. They cover the learning outcomes of the concentration and allow students to deepen their knowledge in the chosen field. They constitute up to 20% of the credit requirement in undergraduate programmes and up to 40% in graduate programmes.
- **Elective courses** are courses selected by the student from a set of alternative optional courses in parallel to the core and concentration courses. They constitute up to 15% of the credit requirement in undergraduate programmes.

Capstone/Final Year Project/Thesis as well as Internship/Experiential Learning are required in specific programmes.

Each academic programme at ULS is carefully designed to achieve well-defined PLOs that reflect ILOs: Professional Excellence, Critical thinking & Innovative Problem Solving, Agile Skills for Modern Graduates, Interdisciplinary Collaboration and Ethical Leadership & Social Responsibility. These ILOS are directly inspired by ULS mission and vision.

3.2.1.3 National qualification

Despite the fact that Lebanon plans a comprehensive 8-level national qualifications framework (NQF) with the help of international partners, covering all types of education and training, there is legislation only on the technical and vocational education and training (TVET) component. However, some ministerial decisions include a form of national qualification requirements, such as the MEHE Decision 488 (taken in 2023), establishing clear rules for teaching and learning for Master programmes. It states, for instance, the number of full-time instructors needed in a specific program, the necessity that they have earned their PhD degree (or the highest possible degree in their field of specialization), and the conditions for supervising Thesis / Projects. ULS fully complies with the guidelines of this decision.

3.2.1.4 International Standards

In addition to complying with national regulations, ULS chooses to incorporate international academic benchmarks in its academic programmes. ULS follows the American credit system with equivalence to ECTS, which facilitates student mobility, academic recognition, and

compatibility with global higher education standards. Several Faculty programmes achieved certifications, accreditations, affiliations, or curriculum alignments (see Section 3.1.6).

3.2.2 *Definition of Intended Learning Outcomes for Study Programmes*

At ULS, the definition of intended learning outcomes is closely tied to the university's commitment to outcomes-based education (OBE) and constructive alignment. It is rooted in a well-established competency framework that guides academic programme development and ensures alignment with the institution's mission, vision, and values. This framework identifies the core competencies that each programme seeks to develop in students, along with the corresponding educational outcomes. It serves as a strategic tool for curriculum design and a means of communication among faculty, instructors, and students, enabling a student-centered learning environment.

Learning outcomes articulate the knowledge, skills, attitudes, and behaviours that students are expected to acquire throughout their academic journey³¹. They are defined at three levels:

- **ILOs** reflect the broader attributes ULS and each faculty aim to instill through the totality of the student experience.
- **PLOs** are specific to each academic programme and ensure alignment with faculty and institutional learning outcomes.
- **CLOs** are derived from PLOs and detail the expected achievements for each course.

This three-tiered outcome structure enables consistency and coherence across the curriculum. PLOs and CLOs are formulated by faculty through a collaborative and consultative process that involves all internal parties and external stakeholders, such as employers or accreditation bodies. They are designed to be clear, measurable, and aligned with international academic standards and national qualifications frameworks. Learning outcomes are mapped to teaching and learning strategies as well as assessment methods, ensuring constructive alignment throughout the curriculum³².

Learning outcomes are reviewed regularly as part of ULS internal QA system, with feedback gathered from students, alumni, faculty, and industry partners. The Faculty Curricular Committee proposes amendments to learning outcomes, which are discussed and approved by Faculty Councils. This process ensures that outcomes remain relevant, coherent, and responsive to evolving educational and professional demands.

In line with the OBE, the Assessment of Learning (AOL) process based on PLOs achievements has recently been launched as a pilot initiative with a select number of courses. This process aims to evaluate how effectively students meet the intended PLOs by CLOs to the broader programme goals. Currently, the assessment is being conducted on a limited scale. The pilot phase serves as a foundation for broader implementation across all faculties once the programme revisions in some faculties and the update of PLOs and CLOs are completed. This

³¹ A comprehensive list of ILOs, PLOs, and CLOs of ULS programmes is provided on the university website.

³² Refer to Mapping Example provided in Appendix 20

initiative ensures that assessments are more aligned with learning outcomes and provides meaningful feedback to improve the quality and effectiveness of teaching and learning³³.

3.2.3 Design of Study Programmes: General Principles and Procedures

The design of study programmes at ULS follows principles and regulations ensuring academic excellence and alignment with institutional values, focusing on providing a balanced, rigorous education that prepares graduates for success in the global workforce.

Alignment with Institutional Mission

Programmes are developed to align with ULS values of high-quality education, community service, and social responsibility, promoting innovation, critical thinking, and the application of technical skills to real-world problems. Graduates are equipped with both technical competencies and essential soft skills to address societal challenges.

Flexibility and Adaptability

Curricula are regularly updated to reflect industry changes and evolving market needs. *For example, technical electives in engineering include Cybersecurity and AI for Computer and Telecommunication students, and Robotics and Automation for Mechatronics students.*

Focus on Learning Outcomes

Each programme is designed to equip students with technical expertise and soft skills reflected in LOs. Internships and pedagogical activities such as project-based learning, capstone projects, lab exercises, and case studies support the achievement of LOs.

Rigorous Assessment Strategies

ULS employs diverse assessment strategies designed to ensure academic rigor and professional readiness. Key strategies include capstone projects and theses to assess knowledge integration, rubric-based grading for consistency and transparency, formative and summative assessments aligned with LOs, the use of digital tools such as LMS quizzes and e-portfolios, timely feedback to support learning, external moderation where applicable, and consistent alignment with CLOs.

Cultural Diversity and Inclusion

ULS promotes inclusion by encouraging participation to its programmes from diverse student backgrounds through scholarships, mentorship, and inclusive admissions. Support services ensure accessibility for students with disabilities. Interdisciplinary projects, cultural events, and student clubs foster intercultural understanding and an equitable academic environment.

Stakeholder Engagement

Study programme development involves collaboration with faculty, alumni, industry professionals, and students. Industry advisory boards guide curriculum updates, and feedback from alumni and career tracking helps assess programme effectiveness. Faculty research and industry partnerships integrate innovations into coursework.

³³ Tools for AOL can be provided upon request.

National Regulations

Faculties also ensure their programmes comply with national regulations from the Lebanese Ministry of Education and Higher Education (MEHE) and meet international benchmarks, including the American credit system, supporting global academic recognition and student mobility.

Process for Approving New Programmes

The approval process for new programmes follows a clearly structured and rigorous approach. Proposals for new programmes or concentrations are first submitted by department Chairs to the Faculty Curriculum Committee for review, following initial acceptance by the Dean. The committee evaluates the proposals and submits its recommendations to the Dean, who, upon approval, forwards them to the Faculty Council. Once endorsed by the Faculty Council, proposals are transmitted, via the Vice-Presidency for Academic Affairs, to the University Curriculum Committee for further discussion. The final approval is granted by the University Council. The university cannot launch the new programme until it receives formal approval from MEHE, following the submission of an application for authorization. This multi-step process ensures that all new programmes are thoroughly reviewed and aligned with the university's academic standards and strategic priorities. All deliberations and decisions are formally documented in meeting minutes.

3.2.4 Applied Regulations for Admission, Assessment, Recognition, and Graduation

All stages of a student's academic journey are exhaustively explained in the ULS RRAA. The following sections refer to specific sections of these rules and highlight the tools ULS uses to check for compliance and to ensure quality of the processes.

3.2.4.1 Admission Regulations

Criteria for Student Eligibility and Selection

Admission to ULS is coordinated by the OAO with all concerned parties (Office of Finance, OR, and academic units) in strict compliance with MEHE regulations. The OAO makes sure to channel students to the programs they are allowed to enrol in in compliance with the regulations of MEHE and professional syndicates.

Once incoming students' files are completed at the OAO (RRAA IV.3.1), students are able to settle their registration fee and enrol online³⁴ in courses via SIS, preceded by a recommended encounter with their individual academic advisor (especially for first-time students). Audit is conducted on the admission requirements, file completion, and course load of students by the OR.

³⁴ In a regular semester, Full-time undergraduate students are students who enrol in 12 to 18 credits and Full-time graduate students are those who enrol in 6 to 9 credits.

Procedures for Local and International Applicants

ULS is firmly engaged in multiplying and diversifying exchange programs with other national and international academic institutions. ULS encourages students to attend one or more semesters abroad, based on the approved exchange program, given the compatibility of courses delivered abroad and their academic plan at ULS. Students are delivered upon registration with an “Equivalence table” mentioning the equivalency of credits between the host university and ULS, especially in the case of transferability of European Credits (roughly equivalent to the double of US Credits. Courses acquired on this basis shall be treated as if registered at ULS. (RRAA IV.3.9)

ULS is also committed to creating a diverse and inclusive academic environment by actively working to attract students from underrepresented groups, including individuals of different religions, regions, nationalities, and those with specific needs stemming from its mission of fairness and equity of treatment. Through the coordinated efforts of the OAO and the Office for the Inclusion, the university implements targeted outreach initiatives, provides accessible information and support services, and promotes equal opportunities for all applicants.

Alignment with National Higher Education Policies

ULS follows a strict transparency policy with its relations with MEHE. The Vice-Presidency for International and Institutional Affairs, under which lies the Office of Government relations, responds in a timely manner to abide by decrees, circulars, and decisions taken by DGHE. All official documents (certificates and diplomas) issued by the OR are submitted via an online platform to MEHE. MEHE also requests regular reports on enrolled students, foreign students, and students eligible for Colloquial exams. The issuance of these confidential and highly sensitive records is compiled by the OIT, the OR, audited by the Office of government relations, verified by the Vice-Presidency for Academic Affairs and Institutional affairs, signed and submitted by the President’s Office. MEHE follows a clear classification of students’ level based on their class level.

ULS classifies its students based on their earned credits and declares this classification in all issued certificates, as per the graduation cycle (RRAA IV.1.3).

3.2.4.2 Assessment Regulations

At ULS, the Assessments Policy ensures alignment with intended learning outcomes, monitoring student progress, and evaluating teaching effectiveness. While the process is a shared academic responsibility, it follows a clear hierarchical structure of oversight allowing to comply with quality assurance guidelines: Deans and Directors provide broad strategic assessment goals, Chairs ensure departmental consistency and compliance, Course Coordinators oversee the design and coherence of assessments, and instructors are responsible for implementation and direct student evaluation.

Operational implementation is supported by the OR, OEM, and OIT each contributing to ensure the quality of the overall process. While the OR organizes and publishes the assessments calendar, enforces deadlines for grade submissions, oversees the release of grades, and manages petitions related to incomplete and make-up, assessments, the OEM has the crucial role of managing exam logistics and archiving exams questions and answer sheets (OIT handles online assessments). The Office for Inclusion of People with Special Needs

works alongside these units to ensure accessibility, while respecting the structure and integrity of the process.

Methods of Student Assessment

The design of assessments at ULS is guided by a reflective and innovative approach that emphasizes the principles of reliability, validity, transparency, fairness and manageability in evaluating student learning as outlined in the Assessments policy. Course coordinators are directly responsible along with instructors of ensuring academic integrity and continuous improvement by monitoring the originality of the questions, the conduct of assessment and the fairness of grading. Assessment results are approved by Chairs and deliberated within the Faculty Council to ensure fairness especially in multi-section courses.

Weight of Different Types of Assessments

The overall student assessment grade weights are outlined in RRAA IV.5.1. Concerning attendance, students exceeding 25 % (7 sessions) of absences after the drop and add period are alerted starting their 5th absence. The list of concerned students is verified by faculties and then sent to the OR to apply an Administrative Withdrawal (AW) grade. Instructors are not entitled to apply any non-academic grade (such as W, AW, I, IP, DW) without the approval of Deans, after close examination of student's appeal.

Continuous assessment: Students missing an assessment for valid documented reasons, should make the necessary arrangements with their instructors for a makeup assessment where appropriate, not later than one week from their missing test or evaluation. Missing a test or an evaluation should remain an accidental event and cannot be repetitive. Otherwise, the student will be granted a score of zero (0) on their assessment.

Final examinations: they are formally held on-campus at the end of the semester as per MEHE regulations allowing for close proctoring of students' performance. Records of students' attendance to the final exam are archived at ULS for possible communication to MEHE. Students missing their final exam, having documented valid reasons should petition for an Incomplete exam (RRAA IV.4.1).

ULS doesn't apply a reassessment possibility for final exams, except for the undergraduate program at FOL. If a student believes that he has been assigned a grade below expectations, he may appeal through petition. The exam copy will be reviewed by the instructor / coordinator/ Chair and inspection results will be communicated to the Faculty Dean who may decide for a grading by a second examiner.

Academic Integrity Policy

To uphold academic integrity and prevent cheating in written assessments, ULS employs two complementary plagiarism and AI-detection tools: Compilatio and Turnitin. These platforms are integrated into the academic workflow to systematically screen student submissions for originality (similarity report threshold is fixed at 20%) and potential misuse of generative AI (threshold fixed at 30%). Compilatio is widely applied across programs, while Turnitin is primarily applied at the graduate level and in research-based assignments for its advanced database comparison. Both platforms are integrated into the LMS platform Moodle to make

their access easier. Reports retrieved from these platforms enable tracking compliance with the aforementioned thresholds. The use of both tools ensures that student work meets ethical standards and aligns with ULS's commitment to quality and responsible academic conduct.

Grading scale

ULS follows an American scoring system scaled over 100 to grade students' assessments (RRAA III.4.1).

Grades are submitted to SIS by instructors. They are reviewed by the course coordinator and approved by the Chair. Once grade distribution and final grades are submitted to the SIS by the instructor and get approved by the Chair, they can no longer be modified except in cases of material error by the instructor: the modified grade should be processed using the "change of grade" form, which includes among other requirements, the reason for such change and has to be granted the approval of Dean and VPAA. Under no circumstances, a change of grade should be made after the lapse of one semester.

3.2.4.3 Recognition Regulations

Transfer students are allowed to enrol at ULS only if their university of origin is recognized by MEHE. (RRAA IV.3.10). To ensure due diligence, transfer requests should be supplemented with the syllabi of the potential transferable courses (specifying the completed number of credits) in addition to the latest official academic transcript (on which are clearly mentioned the completed number of credits, the obtained grade and the number of credits per completed course) for approval by the concerned faculty.

Foreign students are welcome to enrol at ULS, provided they follow a clear and structured admission process. (RRAA IV.3.9). The equivalence between ECTS and American credits is guaranteed in terms of number of credits and number of hours of teaching. At the undergraduate programme, one American credit is equivalent to approximately 1.7 to 2 ECTS credits, 15 contact hours, and 30 self-study hours. At the graduate programme, one American credit is equivalent to approximately 2.5 to 3 ECTS credits, 15 contact hours, and 45 to 60 self-study hours.

Students from a TVET background have to enrol in remedial courses of bridging programs (at FPH, for instance) to be eligible to enrol in undergraduate studies.

3.2.4.4 Graduation Regulations

Degree completion requirements

The requirements for graduation are outlined in RRAA IV.7.2, and the graduation procedure is in IV.7.3.

The academic eligibility of graduating students is verified by the faculties, based on information provided by the OR. Twice each semester, the OR sends Chairs a list of senior students who may be eligible for graduation: once during the semester for planning purposes, and again after final grades are released to confirm eligibility. Chairs review each student's academic plan and transcript to ensure all academic requirements are met.

Students who do not meet graduation requirements are advised to take corrective academic measures, such as retaking failed courses, repeating courses to improve their GPA, or changing their concentration to better align with their strengths. To ensure compliance with this guidance, students are required to submit a petition outlining their intended actions, which must be reviewed and approved by their academic advisor.

Time limits for programme completion

To maintain academic standards and ensure timely progress toward graduation, ULS sets clear time limits for the completion of each academic program as per MEHE's regulations. These limits vary by degree and are designed to provide flexibility while ensuring that students remain on track (RRAA IV.7.1).

Returning students who have been inactive for several semesters must also petition for reenrolment. In such cases, the inactive semesters are not counted toward the time to degree, though the student may be required to retake certain courses to realign with the current program requirements.

Procedures for awarding degrees or certificates

At the end of each semester, ULS proceeds with the graduation of students who have met the degree requirements. A diploma is delivered to each student, signed by the President, the Dean of Faculty, and the Registrar, along with two certified copies, the official transcript, and the diploma supplement that explains some particularities related to the academic program. The eligibility for graduation of senior students is examined by faculties in their last prospective semester, verified by the OR, and relayed to the Commencement ceremony committee to have an estimate of potential participants (usually in July). A pinning ceremony may be organized by faculties highlighting Honors /Recognition of students (RRAA IV.6).

3.2.5 Transparency and Public Information about the Programmes

ULS is committed to transparency by ensuring that comprehensive, accurate, and accessible information about its academic programmes, policies, and activities is systematically communicated to all stakeholders through a variety of structured and effective channels.

3.2.5.1 Dissemination of Regulatory Texts and Policies

Maintaining transparency is of utmost importance for ULS, and this is achieved through the dissemination of regulatory texts such as ULS Bylaws, Academic Staff Manual, Rules and Regulations for Academic Affairs, Rules and Regulations for Scientific Research,³⁵ and institutional policies. These texts, approved by the University Council, are made accessible both internally and through the university's official website. This ensures that all stakeholders, including students and Academic and Administrative Staff, are well-informed about the university's standards and procedures. Transparency supports an environment of trust and accountability, where everyone understands their rights, responsibilities, and the

³⁵ All Bylaws and Rules and Regulations texts are available on the university's website and provided in Appendices 2, 3, 5, 7 & 14

criteria by which they are evaluated. It also ensures that decisions are made consistently and fairly, promoting a culture of integrity and openness. Clearly outlining the university's policies and regulations promotes a culture of quality across its academic and administrative activities.

3.2.5.2 Programme documentation

The programme documentation and accessibility in all ULS faculties are ensured through the academic plans, transcripts, and course description (Syllabus). By systematically recording all processes, decisions, and feedback, the university privileges an environment of accountability and openness. This thorough documentation enables all stakeholders to access and review relevant information for well-informed decision-making. This ensures that all ULS academic entities communicate transparently about their curriculum updates, programme evaluations, and policy changes, facilitating continuous improvement and maintaining high academic standards.

An academic plan shows all the courses required to obtain a given degree in a given programme. It keeps students on track and helps to ensure that they are registered in the right courses each semester in full respect of the programme requisites and their programme of study. The academic plan also provides a description of every course, the needed prerequisite courses, or co-requisite courses, the passing grade, and the course's classification. The academic plan helps in estimating how many semesters and courses are left until a student is potentially eligible to graduate.

The course catalogue summarizes all pertinent information on courses: course description, prerequisites, corequisites, number of credits, offering unit, and programme of affiliation.

The ULS academic transcript lists all the courses registered by students per semester during their academic journey, the letter grades, the number of credits earned, the credit quality points, and the term and cumulative GPA. The transcript also includes remarks on the student's academic performance: Dean's Honor List, Academic recognition, withdrawal from courses, repeated courses, etc.

3.2.5.3 Accessible information regarding the programme content

Comprehensive details about all ULS offered programmes, contract sheets, plan of study, course offerings, syllabi, course materials are available to be accessed by students through different platforms:

- General information about the programme (degree offered, array of concentrations, number of credits to graduate, plan of study, career opportunities, etc.) are accessible on the university's website, as well as in hard copies at the AOA.
- Students' academic plan, unofficial transcript, courses offered, classes schedule, attendance, activity grades, and overall grades are accessible through the SIS.
- Course syllabi, course supporting material (readings, articles, notes, PPT, recordings), and assignments are accessible through the Moodle and Teams platforms. The course's content, reference books, time structure, and workload are documented in standardized

syllabi format, ensuring consistency and clarity for students and efficient coordination purposes between instructors and course coordinators.

3.2.5.4 Channels of Communication

Effective communication channels with students ensure a supportive and engaging academic environment through easily accessing important information, receiving timely updates, and voicing their concerns or suggestions. By providing multiple platforms for interaction, such as email, online portals, social media, and face-to-face meetings, ULS accommodates diverse communication preferences and ensures that every student feels academically well-oriented, heard, and valued, which contributes to a better teaching and learning experience and higher levels of student satisfaction, retention, and success. Moreover, ULS maintains robust communication through the SIS, university email, website, and Moodle, ensuring timely responsiveness, feedback collection, and continuous improvement of the student experience³⁶:

- ULS E-mail Account (@student.uls.edu.lb)

Each ULS student is assigned a unique ULS e-mail address. This ULS e-mail address is the unique official means of digital communication between the university administration, Academic Staff, and students. The student's e-mail address will remain the same throughout the student's enrolment at the university.

- SIS

All students enrolled at ULS get access to the university SIS, which provides all digital support services (e.g., check academic plan, access unofficial transcript, view course catalogue, view activity grades, file a petition, check individual financial statement, etc.). The credentials used to access SIS are provided by the IT department to the student when the e-mail address is created.

- Moodle and Teams E-Learning Platforms

All registered students get access to the Moodle and Teams e-Learning Platform facilities per registered course, providing them access to the posted resources of their courses (syllabus of the course, course material, books, links, URLs, etc.), allowing them to interactively participate to their classes' activities as organized and scheduled by their instructors (homework, forum, chat, tests, etc.) facilitating their learning experience.

3.2.5.5 Communication of Academic and Extracurricular Activities

Academic and extracurricular activities support students' overall development by acquiring technical and soft skills such as teamwork, leadership, creativity, and a sense of community. Whether through academic and cultural clubs, sports teams, cultural events, or community service initiatives, these activities provide students with opportunities to apply classroom

³⁶ Refer to ULS RRAA (Appendix 3)

knowledge in real-world contexts and to develop lifelong skills that complement their academic pursuits³⁷.

Each faculty meticulously plans upcoming academic, cultural, and extracurricular events in accordance with the University Bylaws. These plans are compiled into a comprehensive document and submitted to the University Council for approval, ensuring alignment with institutional goals and available resources. Each faculty ensures that students are informed, well in advance, about scheduled activities. Following each event, communication efforts continue to celebrate and highlight students' achievements through the university's social media platforms and email newsletters, press releases, and, when necessary, television coverage.

3.2.5.6 Faculty's Annual Report

At the end of each academic year, each faculty compiles an annual report that encompasses updates at the programme level, detailed statistics, challenges met, and a summary of academic and extracurricular activities and achievements. This ensures transparency and supports ongoing evaluation and improvement of academic and extracurricular offerings.

3.2.5.7 Methodology for Effective Communication at ULS

Before any communication of any academic or extracurricular offering, ULS adheres strictly to three fundamental methodological steps:

- **Data collection:** Every message is grounded in reliable, up-to-date data, validated by the relevant entity and approved by the appropriate higher authority.
- **Message design and creation:** The information is presented in a clear, coherent, trendy, and accessible manner.
- **Message distribution:** Targeted dissemination is planned according to the specific characteristics of the audiences and channels, to ensure maximum effectiveness in reaching the public and achieving objectives.

3.3 QA in Teaching and Learning

3.3.1 Continuous Monitoring and Periodic Review of Study Programmes: Applied Instruments and Procedures

3.3.1.1 Programme Review in Alignment with Industry Trends and Practical Learning

The University Curriculum Committee, along with the Faculty Curriculum Committees, oversees the programme review processes in consultation with faculty advisory boards. These boards include representatives from leading sectors of the labour market relevant to each faculty. This process is aligned with current employment trends to ensure curricula remain relevant and prepare students for both present and future challenges. Practical learning

³⁷ Appendix 21 provides a list of extracurricular activities organized by each Faculty in the academic year 2024-2025.

experiences are integrated to enhance skill development and application, complementing theoretical foundations.

3.3.1.2 Relevance and Alignment of Programme Review with National and International Standards

The revision of programmes is consistently aligned with both national and international standards. The aim is to ensure that academic offerings remain current and relevant in the global educational landscape, reflecting the latest advancements and best practices in each field of study. By adhering to national educational guidelines and international accreditation standards, ULS endorses the quality and rigor of its programmes while remaining compliant with regulatory requirements and enhancing its institutional reputation. Compliance facilitates recognition of ULS graduates by employers, academic institutions, and professional bodies worldwide.

3.3.1.3 Programme Updates Informed by Internal Stakeholders' Feedback and Benchmarking

Faculties take into consideration feedback from students gathered through a biannual questionnaire, as well as input collected by student advisors, coordinators, and Chairs of departments. Furthermore, they conduct programme benchmarking, comparing curriculum content, teaching methods, and learning outcomes against leading national and international academic institutions. This benchmarking process involves faculty members, curriculum committees, and external experts who assess best practices and industry standards to ensure the curriculum meets the highest academic and professional standards.

3.3.1.4 Programme Updates Informed by Strategic Academic Partnerships

ULS enhances its teaching, research, and professional growth through strategic academic partnerships, providing Academic Staff and students with opportunities for international exposure, advanced research, and career development. These partnerships ensure that programme reviews maintain academic offerings relevant, competitive, and globally aligned. They also provide opportunities for benchmarking, academic exchange, collaborative research, and acquisition of best practices.

For instance, FEBA demonstrates this commitment through partnerships such as double degree programmes with the University of Bordeaux and Rennes School of Business, promoting global business education. Additional collaborations like Pôle Entrepreneur Étudiant de Lorraine (PEEL), Fulbright, student exchanges with French institutions, and Agence Universitaire de la Francophonie (AUF) further enrich students' academic and cultural experiences. Similarly, all ULS faculties benefit from strategic partnerships that help align programmes with international standards and enhance teaching and learning practices³⁸.

³⁸ Refer to Table 1 for Strategic Partnerships at ULS

3.3.1.5 Programme Revision and Approval Process

The revision of programmes follows a structured procedure similar to the process of approving new programmes (see Section 3.2.3). This multi-step process ensures that any updates or additions to the programmes are thoroughly reviewed and aligned with ULS academic standards and goals. All meetings and decisions are documented.

3.3.2 *Surveys for Evaluation of Teaching and Learning*

As clearly stated earlier in this report, student feedback plays a crucial role in evaluating and improving the quality of education at ULS. The university implements a comprehensive course evaluation process covering course content, teaching methods, and assessment strategies. Conducted at the end of each semester, students complete electronic surveys³⁹ consisting of 30 questions for each course, with their final grades accessible contingent on participation. The feedback is used by instructors, Chairs of departments, and Deans to identify strengths and areas for improvement, contributing to continuous development. The evaluation criteria include course content and organization, class management and delivery, assessment of learning, and overall course effectiveness. Students are also encouraged to provide constructive comments for further enhancements.

The Continuing Education programs and pedagogical training organized by CTL and CCE also contribute to QA through systematic evaluation of training initiatives⁴⁰. By employing comprehensive surveys and feedback mechanisms⁴¹, the programs actively engage participants, including staff, faculty, and external attendees, to assess the effectiveness of the offerings⁴². It ensures that insights are shared with trainees, promoting an environment of accountability and enhancement, ultimately enriching the learning experience for everyone involved.

In addition to course evaluations, ULS launched the Graduate Survey⁴³ in January 2024 to assess satisfaction and academic readiness, inspired by a Florida State University alumni assessment workshop. Distributed via Symplicity, the survey is mandatory for diploma collection and received 546 responses across eight faculties. Results showed high satisfaction rate (96.5%) and very high placement rate upon graduation (92%).

3.3.3 *Collected Data on Student Performance and Student Success*

To assess and improve the quality of its programs, ULS continuously collects and analyzes data on student performance across multiple dimensions. This includes key indicators such as the selectivity ratio, retention ratio, success rate, dropout rate, average duration, and average

³⁹ The survey of Course Evaluation by Students is provided in Appendix 16.7.

⁴⁰ Samples of CTL Evaluation surveys are provided in Appendix 22

⁴¹ Samples of CCE questionnaires are provided in Appendix 23.

⁴² The CCE designs its offerings based on surveys that assess the needs within the ULS community, as well as benchmarking against national and international markets.

⁴³ The Graduate Survey is provided in Appendix 24

GPA. These ratios help guide decisions regarding student support, curriculum development, and resource allocation. Table 5 provides these statistics for Graduate Programme Students over the period 2019-2025.

Table 5 – Graduate Students’ Performance Data by Cohort

GRADUATE Students by Cohort excluding Transfer Students							
Cohort	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
# Applicants	431	273	375	624	575	418	357
#Accepted Applicants	316	193	301	438	397	331	231
#Newcomers	277	177	273	348	355	307	150
#Newcomers Coming from ULS	131	91	131	155	141	158	70
Ratio of Students Coming from ULS	47.29%	51.41%	47.99%	44.54%	39.72%	51.47%	46.67%
#Newcomers Foreign	2	4	4	6	10	8	3
#Graduates	137	71	119	112	20	NA	NA
Success Rate	49.46%	40.11%	43.59%	32.18%	5.63%	NA	NA
Drop Out Rate	6.50%	7.91%	3.66%	5.46%	3.38%	5.21%	NA
Average Duration (Terms - Summer Included)	2.0891	1.8169	1.8000	1.7571	1.3400	NA	NA
Average GPA	3.4038	3.4303	3.4429	3.4893	3.4921	NA	NA

The selectivity ratio highlights the ratio of accepted students to the number of applicants, reflecting the competitiveness of the graduate programs. The retention ratio demonstrates the ratio of newcomers to the accepted applicants, indicating the success of ULS in retaining students within the program.

Table 6 – Additional Indicators for Graduate Student Cohorts

Graduate Cohort	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Selectivity ratio	73.32%	70.70%	80.27%	70.19%	69.04%	79.19%	64.71%
Retention Ratio	87.66%	91.71%	90.70%	79.45%	89.42%	92.75%	64.94%

Table 5 and Table 6 highlight the following trends:

- Fluctuations in the selectivity ratio for graduate students over the studied period, reflecting the university's evolving admission competitiveness. The highest selectivity ratio occurred in 2021 at 80.27%. In contrast, the selectivity ratio is projected to decrease in 2025, reaching 64.71%, indicating a potential shift in admission strategies and the evolving admissions landscape influencing the selection process.
- A high retention ratio (reaching 92.75% in 2024) indicating strong academic and support services that help students enrol and remain in the program.
- A relatively stable ratio of students coming from ULS (between 40% and 50%), demonstrating the priority given to ULS graduates in admissions, a critical aspect in light of a new regulation set by MEHE⁴⁴ limiting the number of students in Master's programmes across Lebanese universities.
- A success rate of graduate students fluctuating over the years, peaking at 49.46% in 2019, with a steady decline observed in subsequent years. This decline can be

⁴⁴ MEHE Decision No. 488 dated 27/06/2023, concerning the regulation of teaching in Master's programs at private HEIs.

attributed to a range of challenges faced by students, including the impact of COVID-19, the severe national economic crisis, and political instability.

- A relatively stable dropout ratio, starting at 6.50% in 2019, peaking in 2020 at 7.91%, and then showing a general decline in subsequent years, with a notable drop to 3.38% in 2023. This decrease in dropout rates is a positive sign, indicating improvements in student retention and support mechanisms.
- A steady increase in average GPA over the years, starting from 3.40 in 2019 and rising gradually to 3.49 in 2023. This consistent improvement in GPA reflects the growing academic performance of students, possibly due to the enhanced curriculum and support services offered by the university, such as pedagogical training and academic advising. The ULS Financial Support Policy, more particularly the merit-based scholarship system, also plays a key role by attracting high-achieving students and motivating enrolled students to maintain strong academic performance in order to retain their scholarships.

Table 7 – Undergraduate Students’ Performance Data by Cohort

Undergraduate Students by Cohort excluding Transfer & Freshman Students							
Cohort	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
# Applicants	994	945	881	1292	1590	1621	1645
#Accepted Applicants	700	651	602	828	1089	1143	1140
#Newcomers	541	490	501	599	795	877	792
#Newcomers Foreign	8	5	9	8	23	26	14
#Graduates	409	355	265	149	7	0	0
Success Rate	75.60%	72.45%	52.89%	24.87%	0.88%	NA	NA
Dropout Rate	8.87%	7.35%	9.38%	5.18%	2.89%	2.05%	0.25%
Average Duration (Terms - Summer Included)	3.4797	3.4400	3.1932	2.7490	2.2571	NA	NA
Average GPA	2.7887	2.8115	2.7339	2.8047	3.0259	NA	NA

Table 8 – Additional Indicators for Undergraduate Student Cohorts

Undergraduate Cohort	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Selectivity ratio	70.42%	68.89%	68.33%	64.09%	68.49%	70.51%	69.30%
Retention Ratio	77.29%	75.27%	83.22%	72.34%	73.00%	76.73%	69.47%

Similarly, the statistics for undergraduate cohorts covering the period 2019-2025 in Table 7 and Table 8 show the following trends:

- A more stable selectivity ratio over the years for the applicants to undergraduate programmes (between 65% and 70%).
- A slight decrease in retention ratio in 2025, with generally high rates fluctuating between 70% and 83%.
- A decrease in success rate in the latest years from almost 72% in 2020, 53% in 2021 to around 25% in 2022 is partly due to the longer duration of certain academic programmes, which delays graduation. For example, the Engineering cohort of 2022 is expected to graduate in 2027, while students in Law programmes typically complete their studies over four years, with graduation projected for 2026.

shows strong satisfaction with graduates' skills and professionalism. Alumni insights further inform programme relevance and career impact. This ongoing input supports curriculum updates and teaching strategies, keeping ULS offerings aligned with academic and industry standards.

Quality Reports by External Experts to Enhance Support Services

Furthermore, ULS engages external experts to evaluate and support its auxiliary units, such as the CTL, the Center for Languages, the CCD, and other units, either independently or in collaboration with international organizations like the AUF, Erasmus+, and USAID to improve academic and support services⁴⁵.

3.4 Special Focus Areas of QA

3.4.1 Infrastructure, Resources, and Learning Environment: Monitoring and Enhancement

3.4.1.1 Infrastructure Review and Enhancement

The monitoring process of learning infrastructure is a joint effort of different academic and administrative entities that are in charge of the multifaceted dimensions of the learning and teaching process.

Monitoring

ULS observes a policy of transparent communication between academic and administrative entities to ensure prompt responses to issues related to infrastructure, which infringe on the learning environment. Specific requests from particular entities are addressed to the VPAA, who dispatches solutions with the proper authority. University Council's meetings are the occasion to highlight the need for academic improvements on a more general level. To support this, the Offices of Campus Management and Procurement conduct regular audits to evaluate the physical adequacy, accessibility, safety, and sustainability of classrooms, laboratories, and the library. The Offices of Registrar and Information Technology reallocate resources to ensure the continuity of course delivery and conduct of assessments. Systematic feedback is collected from instructors and students to ensure improvement in the long term. In addition to that, QASC has implemented a workflow of regular reviews of infrastructure and learning environment indicators, incorporating input from academic and administrative units. External benchmarking and peer reviews are utilized to align facilities and services with best practices.

Enhancement

Based on audit findings, renovation projects, technology upgrades, and space optimization initiatives are implemented to maintain a modern and well-equipped campus. The ULS Main Campus consists of four adjacent buildings, along with the FOE building located 100 meters away. Classroom distribution across these spaces is strategically managed to accommodate the growing number of course sections and student enrollment demands. For instance, the

⁴⁵ Check Section 3.4.2 for more details about the carried missions.

IT system has recently been upgraded to meet external certification requirements with ITLS, ensuring compatibility for computer literacy courses. To support the increasing demand for extracurricular activities, including sports, cultural events, and environmental initiatives, common spaces on campus have been enhanced, providing students with improved opportunities for engagement and community building. These are temporary solutions waiting for a more comprehensive strategic development of physical resources.

3.4.1.2 Resources

The deployment of resources is of utmost importance in the efforts conducted by ULS to optimize human, time, and technological resources.

Monitoring

To ensure an optimal deployment of Academic Staff, course offerings are closely monitored by VPAA, with a maximum of four sections per semester assigned to part-time instructors. Strict enforcement of the full-time teaching load rule allows full-time instructors to dedicate more time to research, administrative responsibilities, and community engagement.

For course time management, teaching activity is tracked through the SIS, which automatically records the number of sessions delivered by each instructor. Similarly, the system calculates student absences and issues alerts when the number of missed classes exceeds the allowed limit.

As for the optimal use of technological resources, the VPAA reminds each faculty to finalize course configurations on SIS, including class activities, grade mapping, and approval authorizations for grade submission at the beginning of each semester.

Enhancement

The institution is able to prioritize teaching resource renewal and the development of programs by integrating digital solutions: investments in e-book integration have led to a significant shift in pedagogical methods, promoting more interactive and flexible learning environments, and reducing unnecessary waste in resources. In addition, regular upgrades of labs and classrooms are conducted.

Additionally, to ensure an efficient conduct of assessments, the number of exam proctors has increased, now maintaining a ratio of 20 students per proctor with the designation of full-time Academic Staff as Head Proctors. Although this excessive use of human resources entails large costs, it has further optimized assessment conditions, ensuring better supervision and exam integrity. In addition, improvement of assessment design and analysis of results is outlined in the Assessments Policy.

To support the monitoring of class time and delivery, face recognition devices have been installed at the entrance of each classroom. Instructors use these devices upon entry and exit, providing accurate records of teaching activity.

3.4.1.3 Learning Environment

By aligning infrastructure and resources, ULS creates conditions that enhance learning outcomes and contribute to overall program quality.

Monitoring

Learning conditions are regularly evaluated through multiple channels, including student satisfaction surveys, course evaluations, classroom observations, and academic performance indicators. Furthermore, areas requiring improvement are closely monitored using key performance indicators (KPIs) such as student retention, graduation rates, research productivity, and satisfaction scores. These metrics help ensure data-driven decision-making.

Complementing these efforts, the Assessment of Learning gradebook plays a key role in identifying both strengths and areas for improvement in course syllabi, teaching methods, and assessment strategies, based on the analysis of student performance data. The targeted CLOs in assessments are conveyed to students in alignment with the OBE approach.

Enhancement

Since instructors, particularly part-timers, are the direct line of contact with students and in charge of delivering courses, an open discussion of course evaluations are conducted by course coordinators to fill the gaps in their performance, maintaining confidentiality and anonymity of survey answers. The recruitment process has been structured and standardized across faculties. Additionally, opportunities for professional growth are disseminated in order to encourage part-timers to seek full-time positions and for full-timers to get promoted. A clear pathway for career advancement and encouraging long-term commitment to ULS is key to the retention of human capital.

On the other hand, the psychological and social well-being of students is supported through counselling services and inclusive campus policies, as well as the development of extracurricular activities.

Findings of quantitative and qualitative surveys addressed to students are integrated into strategic planning. It has led to the creation of new entities: PULSE, Center of Export Promotion, Office of CSR, Office of Inclusion of People with Special Needs, which respond to the assessment of needs. In parallel, there has been a noticeable increase in certifications within program concentrations, and continuing education training reflecting a stronger alignment with industry standards and student engagement.

3.4.2 Student Support and Advisory Services: Monitoring and Enhancement

ULS employs a comprehensive approach to student support, encompassing academic guidance, high-quality resources for learning, career readiness, and extracurricular opportunities.

The university strengthens student advising by increasing meetings between students and academic advisors, helping monitor progress and provide timely support. Advisors assist students in setting academic and career goals. For students with a low GPA, advisors actively

monitor progress and send advisory notifications to those struggling academically. Additionally, one-on-one meetings are scheduled with advisors to discuss academic challenges. *For instance, to further enhance student support, FPSIR holds regular meetings, including SWOT analysis sessions at the start and end of each semester, to understand and address challenges students face. Advisors also use surveys at the end of the semester to gather feedback on students' academic experience and satisfaction with support services.*

To support the learning experience, ULS ensures the availability of high-quality resources, including standardized syllabi, instructional materials from leading publishers, and access to extensive digital resources such as JSTOR and EBSCO. Course materials are based on textbooks from renowned international publishers such as Pearson, McGraw-Hill, Palgrave, Wiley, Cengage, etc. *For instance, FEBA has digitized most of its textbooks, providing students and instructors with access to e-books and expanded resources on the interactive platforms of Pearson and McGraw-Hill (Connect). Ongoing efforts are being made by several faculties, such as FTHM, FPSIR, and the FOE, to provide students with access to international eBooks, depending on the availability of titles that align with their programmes and disciplines.*

Professors and clinical instructors of FPH conduct interactive lectures and case studies, enhancing students' problem-solving skills. A nursing simulation lab has been fully renovated, alongside an equipped physiotherapy lab, ensuring students receive hands-on training in a modern environment. Early exposure to clinical settings begins in the second year, with students visiting diagnostic centers and hospitals. Supervised training by certified Radiologic Technologists, registered nurses, and licensed physiotherapists enhances the practical experience.

The Human Rights Legal Clinic and the internships at the Bar Association Legal Assistance Commission are key components of student support and practical training in FOL, enabling law students to apply their academic knowledge to real-world legal and human rights challenges and strengthen their engagement with the legal and human rights communities in Lebanon.

To preserve research integrity, ULS ensures AI detection across all languages handled by the university, ULS has subscribed to a new plagiarism and AI detection software, Compilatio, addressing the limitations of the existing system used by the network of peer universities. ULS has fully integrated Compilatio with its LMS (Moodle), making it easier for Academic Staff to conduct plagiarism and AI detection checks on all research projects.

Beyond academics, ULS enhances the student experience through extracurricular activities like competitions, conferences, and seminars, which help students develop critical professional skills and build connections with industry leaders. *For instance, the internship program at FPH provide students with hands-on clinical experience in hospitals and diagnostic centers, and the final year projects at FOE provide them with valuable hands-on experience through exploring process control in industrial production and designing innovative, market-oriented products that respond to emerging consumer needs.*

The CCD continuously diversifies and improves its offering of workshops and training to support student development and successful professional integration.

Furthermore, ULS collaborates with external experts and international organizations like AUF and USAID to evaluate and enhance its auxiliary units, such as the CTL, Center for Languages, and CCD, improving academic and support services. Three missions were recently carried out in this context:

1. In partnership with USAID, the CCD received support in institutionalizing the center, improving staff competencies, and implementing the "Symplicity" IT system to enhance student employability.
2. With AUF, the structure of the Center for Languages was reviewed, addressing challenges in language instruction and proposing updates to course content and teaching methods, including training on competency-based approaches.
3. Also with AUF, the CTL received an assessment of its structure and services, resulting in a development plan and recommendations to enhance teaching quality and student learning in line with institutional goals.

3.4.3 Academic Staff: Recruitment, Performance Monitoring, Further Training

The quality of instructors is crucial for delivering high-quality education. Ensuring highly-qualified instructors involves:

- Hiring instructors with advanced degrees, relevant certifications, and substantial experience in their fields.
- Evaluating teaching methods and effectiveness.
- Encouraging instructors to engage in continuous learning and professional development to stay updated with the latest advancements in their fields.
- Supporting instructors' research activities and ensuring their research contributes to the academic community and informs their teaching.
- Retaining talented instructors by offering growth opportunities, recognizing their contributions, and creating a positive work environment.

3.4.3.1 Recruitment

ULS recruitment philosophy relies on a merit-based approach, prioritizing academic qualifications, teaching ability, research experience, and professional accomplishments. The university adopts a clear recruitment policy and procedure for Academic Staff. The policy ensures the selection of the most qualified candidates for teaching positions. It favors candidates holding a PhD or the highest degree in the specific area of specialization or practitioners having a sound professional experience.

The recruitment process begins with a call for applications posted on the university's website and social media platforms, though it may also be initiated by unsolicited CV submissions. All applications are reviewed by an ad-hoc recruitment committee at the Faculty level composed of two or three full-time members, along with additional members invited based on the applicant's field of expertise. The Director of CTL may also be involved in the recruitment process to ensure that the selected candidate aligns with ULS teaching philosophy and possesses the necessary pedagogical skills and tools for effective instruction. CVs are first

screened by the ad-hoc recruitment committee to ensure the candidates hold degrees recognized by MEHE and that their profiles align with the specific requirements of the position. Shortlisted candidates are then invited for interviews. Those with limited teaching experience are asked to deliver a teaching audition (demo-lecture) on a given topic to assess their communication, pedagogical skills as well as their knowledge in the field. Each committee member completes an evaluation form, which informs the final recruitment decision⁴⁶.

ULS prioritizes hiring instructors with degrees from internationally recognized institutions and significant academic or professional experience. ULS recruits highly regarded professionals and senior experts such as judges, chairs of syndicates, CEOs, and other distinguished leaders in their fields, whose real-world insights bring exceptional value to academic programmes and enhance the bridge between theory and practice. Their global academic backgrounds enrich the learning experience and enhance students' international outlook. Additionally, visiting professors and guest lecturers with practical global experience are regularly invited.

The Academic Staff deployment ensures that the number of instructors is carefully managed to maintain an optimal student-to-teacher ratio and ensure effective education delivery through:

- Aligning the number of instructors with student enrolment projections to ensure manageable class sizes and adequate support.
- Keeping a balanced number of full-time and part-time instructors to provide flexibility in staffing and manageable workload for instructors.
- Developing strategic hiring plans to address current and future staffing needs based on programme growth and faculty retirements.
- Promoting background diversity among instructors to provide varied perspectives and enhance the learning environment in alignment with the ULS mission.

3.4.3.2 Performance Monitoring

ULS implements a structured, multi-source system to monitor Academic Staff performance.

Student Course Evaluations

At the end of each semester, students complete mandatory online evaluations assessing course content, teaching delivery, assessment methods, and overall satisfaction. Results inform instructor self-evaluation and contribute to programme and teaching enhancements.

Evaluation by Chairs of Departments and Deans

For contract renewal or promotion of full-time Academic Staff, they submit a comprehensive file that includes student evaluations, a teaching portfolio, research output, and community service contributions. The Chair of the Department and the Dean assess the file and provide

⁴⁶ Evaluation forms are provided in Appendix 16.4.

recommendations to the VPAA. When the Chair is being evaluated, the Dean and departmental instructors participate in the process through an anonymously administered survey. Evaluation results are shared with the concerned Chair and discussed during performance review meetings.

Classroom Observations (via students' petitions and advising)

Continuous student input is shared with Chairs of departments heads or course coordinators to improve teaching practices.

LOs and Student Performance

Monitoring student performance and learning outcomes through tools like the AOL helps track progress. Analyzing these results contributes to assess teaching effectiveness.

Technology and Learning Management Systems (LMS)

Monitoring student engagement on platforms like Moodle and Teams tracks interaction with course materials and assignments. Reviewing how instructors use technology helps assess its impact on student learning.

3.4.3.3 Further Training and Research Support

The CTL supports instructors and provides them with the necessary assistance to improve their teaching practices by organizing specific training sessions, covering didactic, pedagogical, and subject-specific aspects as well as facilitating access to workshops. In addition to sessions on pedagogy, technology in education, and student engagement, these initiatives help instructors develop skills to improve the student learning experience, enhance their well-being, and support their leadership growth, as demonstrated by sessions like "Psychology of teaching and learning in crisis times" and "Mental health in the workplace". The CTL also provides a listening and support service for instructors based on the semi-annual results of the course evaluation by students. Additionally, through its own international cooperation agreements and international programmes provided by foreign embassies in Lebanon, ULS offers its Academic Staff a range of mobility opportunities, supporting their professional development and enhancing academic and expertise exchange.

ULS supports the research activities of its Academic Staff in accordance with the Rules and Regulations for Scientific Research⁴⁷ and the strategic objectives outlined in its 2021–2026 Development Plan. The university provides them with the necessary facilities by ensuring a conducive environment for research. ULS grants teaching and administrative load reductions according to professorial ranks to support their research advancement, emphasizing the importance of integrating research outcomes into teaching. ULS supports its researchers through sabbatical leaves, international mobility, access to research databases, and participation in conferences, while actively encouraging publication in peer-reviewed, internationally recognized journals.

⁴⁷ Refer to Appendix 15

3.4.3.4 Measures to retain qualified Academic Staff

ULS offers a comprehensive compensation & benefits package, both financial and non-financial, to its full-time instructors as a strategic measure to attract, retain, and support highly qualified Academic Staff. This package includes competitive, transparent salaries based on rank and exclusivity, healthcare coverage, seniority-based end-of-service indemnities, and educational funding for instructors' children. Instructors also receive transportation and accommodation allowances for professional mobility. ULS values long-term commitment through seniority recognition with clearly defined contractual terms. Additionally, full-time instructors are granted access to research resources and funding to support their research output.

As a learning environment and as part of its retention strategy, ULS is committed to providing its Academic Staff with opportunities to strengthen their competencies and ensure professional growth, such as access to workshops, international training programs, and academic mobility initiatives.